

grass-fed ground beef. If I can't spend \$9 to \$12 for a pound of the good stuff, I'd rather eat something else, at least when it comes to beef (that's a side effect of just having finished *The Omnivore's Dilemma*).

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3. When you buy less, less goes to waste

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Seems obvious, no? But I used to feel that I should grab as much as I had time to buy at the grocery store. After all, getting to the store, waiting in line, etc., is time-consuming, and I wanted to make as few trips as possible.

What I didn't account for is that when you buy more than you can eat fresh in a week, you have to take time to prepare it for the freezer, or you'll be spending time dumping it into the trash. Cleaning out the fridge is work, too—and if you are regularly dumping leftovers, you are wasting money. Sometimes I open a friend's fridge and I can't see the back or the walls because there is so much food stuffed in there. They don't even know what they have—so of course a lot of it is going to end up in the garbage.

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4. A budget gets you excited about freebies again

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Relive your college days! Remember when all a college group had to do to

ensure turnout at a meeting was to post a flyer offering free pizza? When I was a broke college student, nothing (well, almost nothing) made me smile more than a free meal.

This weekend, my in-laws visited, and, while I was away for the day, they all shopped and cooked barbecue at my house. I came home to a fridge *full* of leftovers, and I was just tickled pink that I don't have to shop for a couple days. Because that means I'll either be able to go under budget, or I'll be able to spend a few bucks on an indulgence. Which brings me to . . .

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5. Booze is expensive

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Time and again, I find that the weeks we go over budget are the ones when we picked up some wine and beer. The hubs and I both enjoy a drink after the kids go to bed, and it's not an indulgence we're interested in sacrificing. I know that beer is cheaper than wine, but I've often wondered how a cocktail (we use store-brand seltzer water with a little liquor) compares to a glass of wine. Inevitably all my research notes get mixed up or spilled on and I've not been able to come up with a good economic model on this point.

Solutions? So far the only ones we have are: get a case of inexpensive wine when you come upon a sale and get boxed wine. And, be really nice